

Gradually, Then Suddenly

INCREMENTAL CHANGES OCCUR at a very deliberate pace.

Winter snow melts, the runoff water follows gravity downhill, washing away soil, then clay, and eventually, cutting into the bedrock itself. Winter, spring, summer, fall, snow, melt, year after year. Hardly visible over decades or even over centuries; after a few millennia, barely the smallest of changes are noticeable.

Five million years later, it becomes the Grand Canyon.

Geologic timescales are very different than our usual frames of reference. It's unlike the pace that humans experience.

This is how the world changes, slowly, a little bit at a time—but it adds up.

In Ernest Hemingway's *The Sun Also Rises*,¹⁶⁸ a character is asked how he went bankrupt: "Two ways. Gradually, then suddenly." That has become a favorite phrase of mine, the closest in wisdom per word to William Goldman's "Nobody knows anything."

Sometimes, big changes can be obvious to spot: When the internet first came along, it was apparent to even Luddites that it was going to change a lot of things. But even when massive change occurs, we can underestimate its impact. This is because of all the smaller, incremental changes that occur without our awareness, beneath our collective notice.

Fire, the wheel, the printing press, electricity, flight, internet, and now AI were all big technological advances. We may recognize a game-changing technology, but we have no idea what the game is going to look like a few decades into the future. The iPhone put an immense amount of computing power in everybody's pocket, but I doubt Steve Jobs ever imagined how mobile telephony would combine with social media to wreak so much havoc on teenagers' lives.

I drive a lot of different automobiles, and recently spent some time behind